

TRUSTMRR · SESSION 3 · DATA FROZEN 30 JUL 2026

Inside the Micro-SaaS Economy

What separates the 20% who build businesses from the 80% who build projects

1,000 startups · 29 variables · \$15.6M monthly revenue

A verified-revenue census of independent software businesses

1,000 rows × 29 fields, snapshot frozen 30 July 2026 — cross-sectional, not a time series

\$15.6M

Combined revenue,
last 30 days

\$334M

Cumulative all-time
revenue recorded

500,597

Active paid
subscriptions

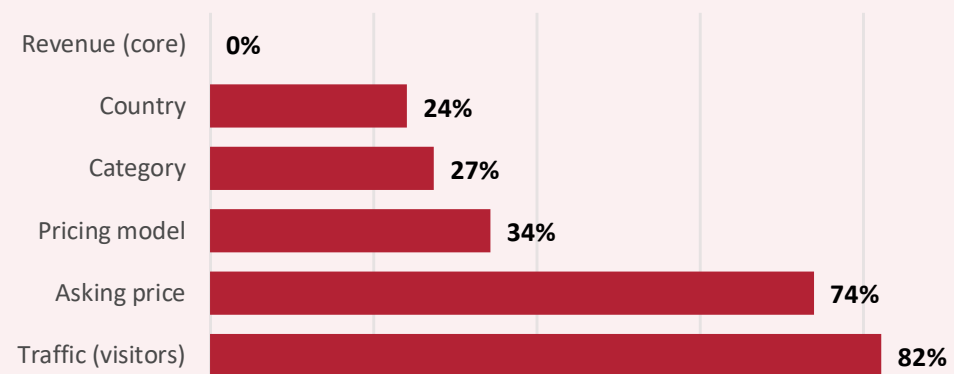
\$400

MEDIAN startup's
monthly revenue

What the file contains

- Revenue windows: 30-day, 3-month, 12-month, all-time
- Subscription economics: MRR, active subs, growth %
- Firmographics: country, category, B2B/B2C, persona
- Distribution: X followers, domain rating, visitors
- Market signals: payment provider, for-sale flag, asking price

Coverage gaps that shape the analysis



The question: what actually predicts revenue?

Moving from description to explanation — and then to a decision rule

1

Segment

Split 1,000 firms by revenue tier, category, audience, geography and distribution asset — then test which splits actually separate outcomes.

2

Reconstruct trend

With no time series, derive an implied monthly path from three nested revenue windows to test whether the cohort is accelerating or plateauing.

3

Isolate levers

Rank candidate drivers by rank correlation with revenue, then test whether they compound when stacked.

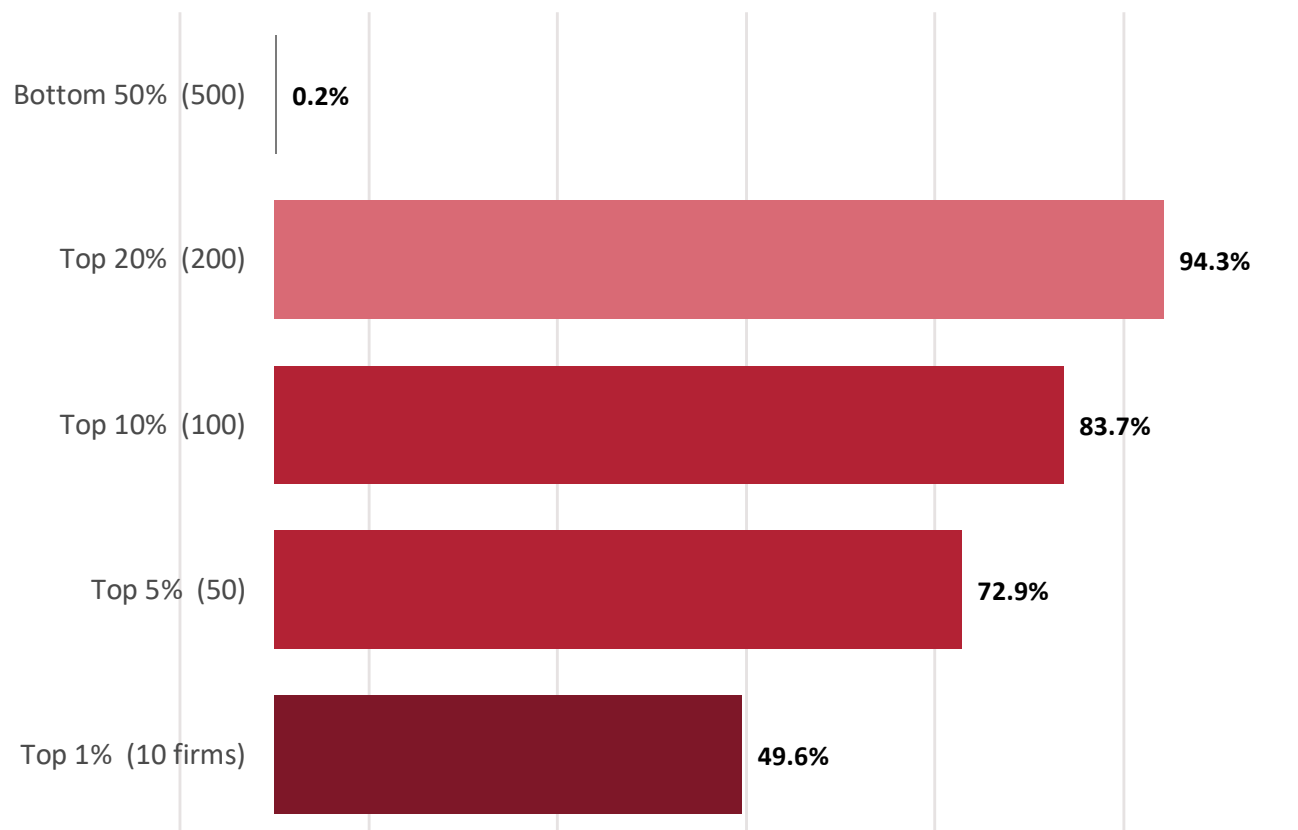
Stated assumptions

- "Last 30 days" is treated as one month; 3-month and 12-month totals are divided by 3 and 12 to give comparable average months.
- Blank category / audience fields are excluded from those cuts, not imputed — 726 rows carry a category.
- $\text{ARPU} = \text{MRR} \div \text{active subscriptions}$, computed only where both are above zero (789 firms).
- Medians lead throughout; means are shown only to expose skew.
- 32 rows report 30-day revenue above their 3-month total. These are logically impossible and excluded from all trend maths.

1

INSIGHT 1 • REVENUE CONCENTRATION

Ten companies earn half the money



Why it matters

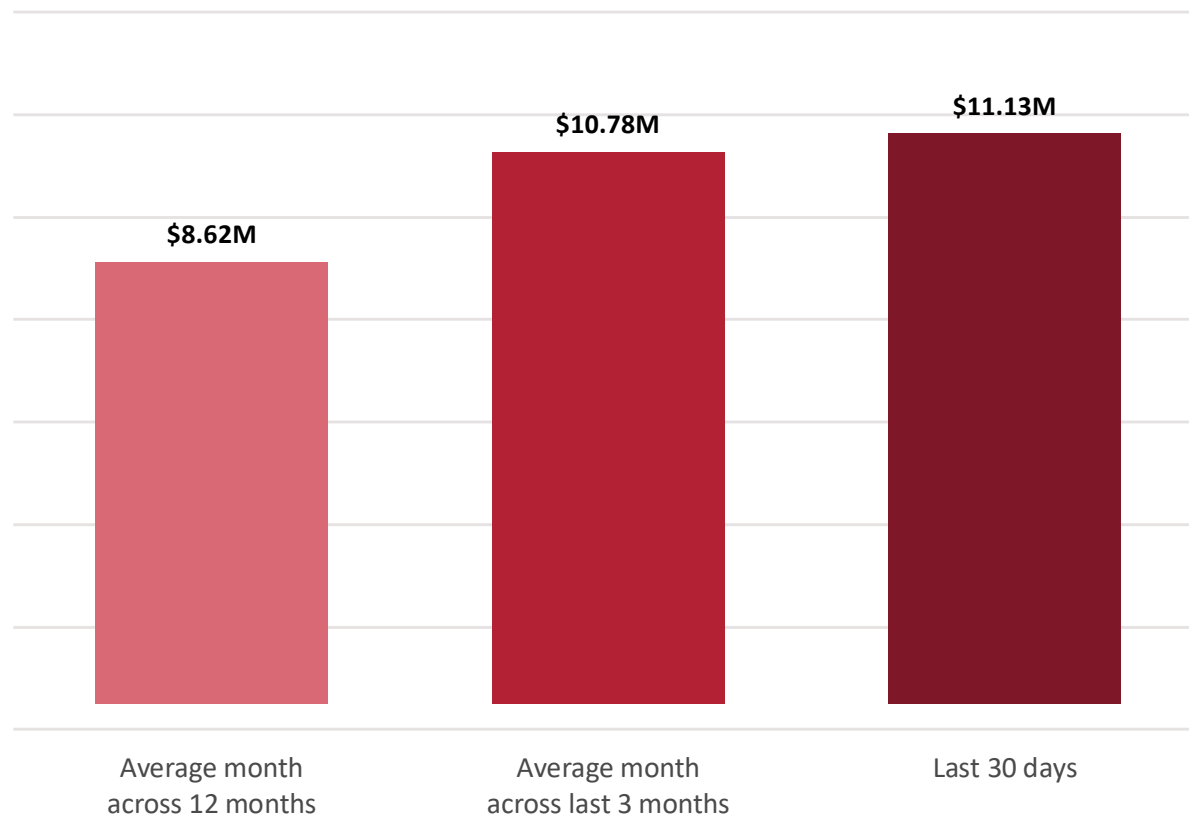
- The 500 smallest firms produced \$30,822 between them in a month — 0.2% of the market.
- 216 firms (21.6%) earned nothing at all in the last 30 days; 101 have never earned a dollar.
- 579 firms (57.9%) sit below \$1,000 a month — below the threshold of a business.
- Mean revenue is 39× the median. Any average quoted from this market is meaningless.

Recommendation: benchmark against the median (\$400), never the mean.

n = 1,000. Shares computed on last-30-day revenue; ranking by the same measure.

Growth over the year — but a flat last quarter

Implied average monthly revenue, 968 firms (32 logically inconsistent rows excluded)



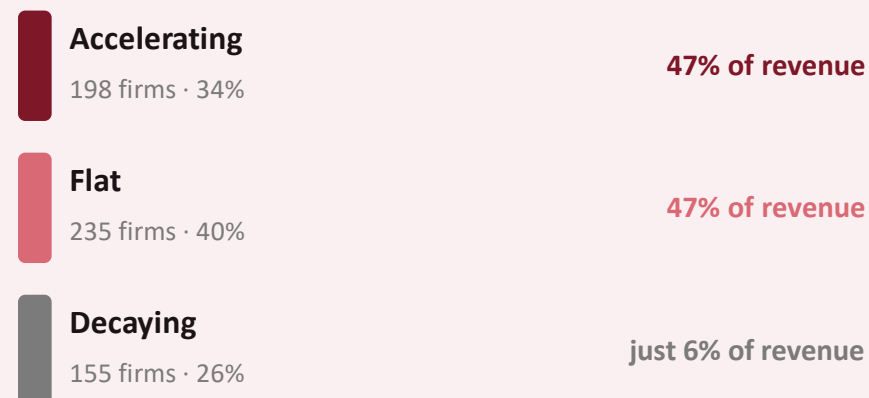
+29.1%

last 30 days vs. the average month of the past year

+3.2%

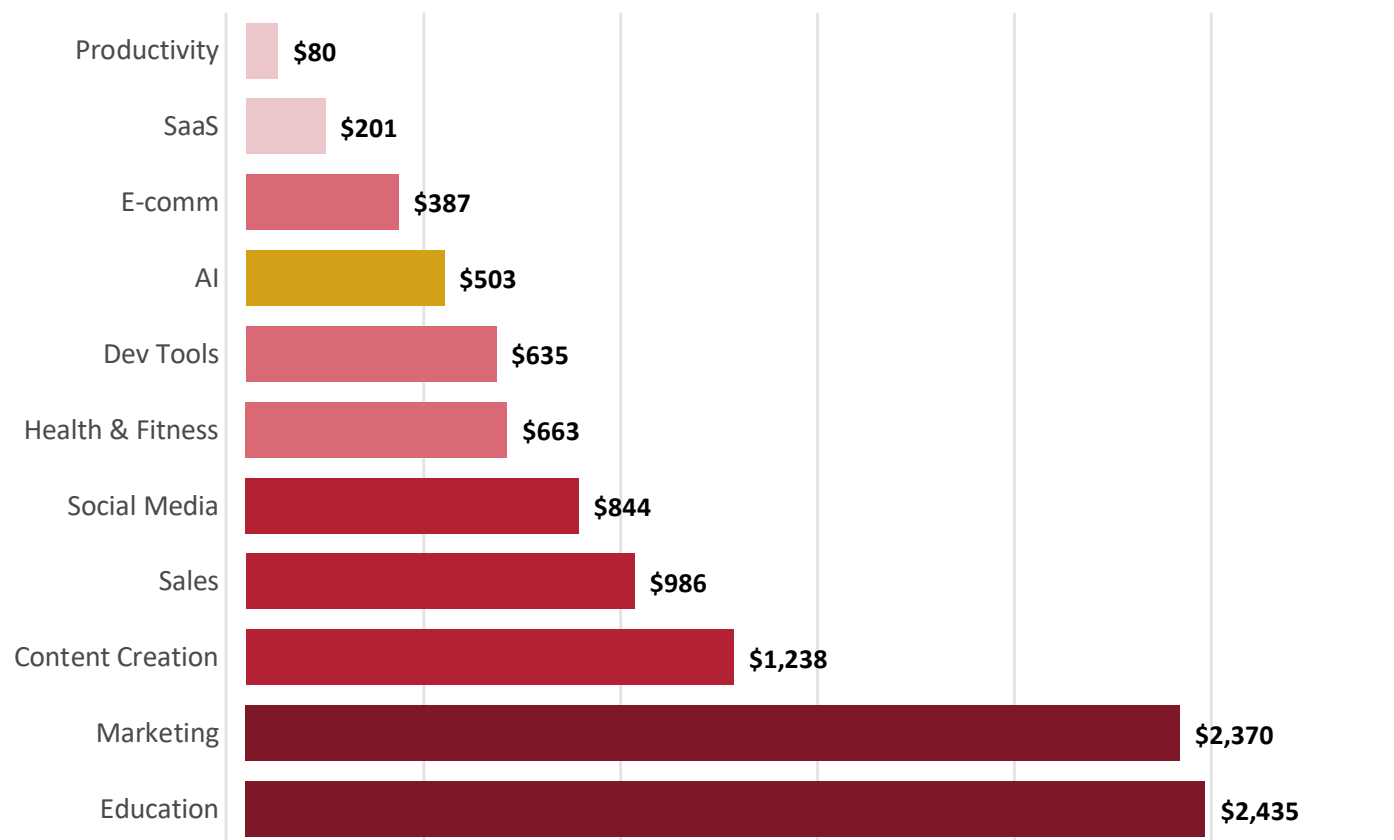
but only vs. the recent three-month run rate

Beneath the average: three cohorts



Cohorts defined on last-30-day revenue vs. the average month of the last 3 months: $\pm 15\%$ band = flat. Active firms only ($\geq \$1,200$ trailing 12-month revenue).

Everyone is building AI. Almost nobody is being paid for it.



The AI paradox

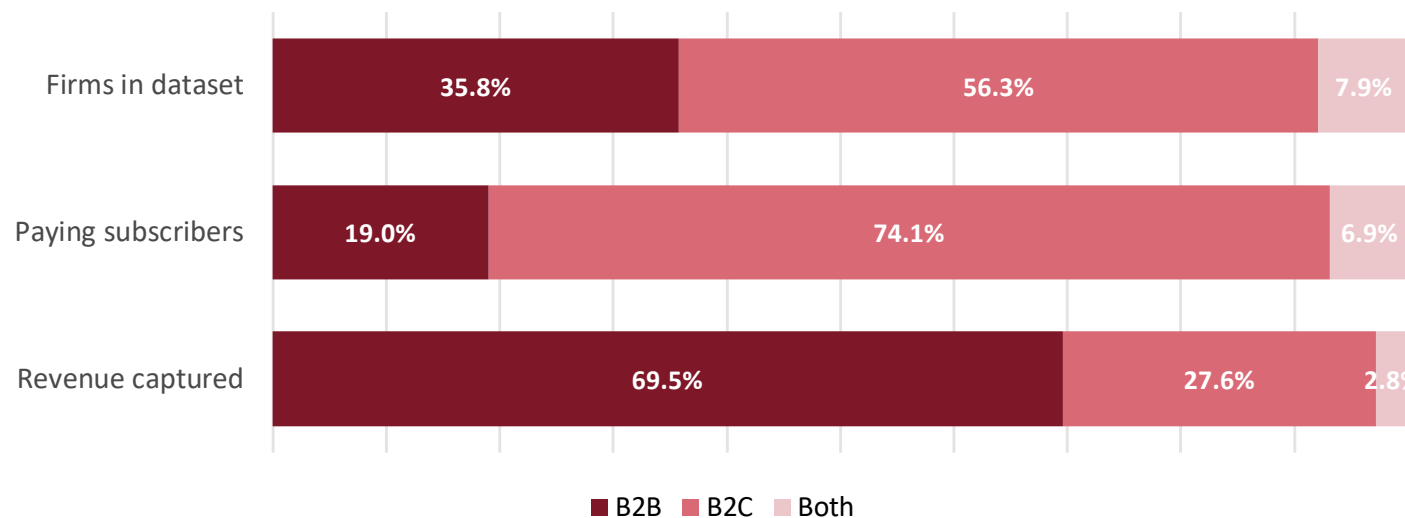
- 27% of all categorised firms call themselves AI — the largest category by far.
- They capture only 15% of revenue: the category under-earns its own headcount.
- Median AI firm: \$503/month — a fifth of the median Education firm.

Why it matters

Category choice is a supply decision, not a demand one. AI is crowded because it is easy to enter, and easy entry compresses price. The boring categories — teaching people things, helping them sell — are where the median founder is actually paid.

B2C wins the customers. B2B wins the money.

Share of the labelled population, of paying subscribers, and of revenue captured



B2C holds three quarters of every paying subscriber in this market — and just over a quarter of the money. B2B does the inverse: a fifth of the customers, seventy per cent of the revenue.

Median revenue per user

\$49.00 **\$9.34**

B2B

B2C — 5.2× lower

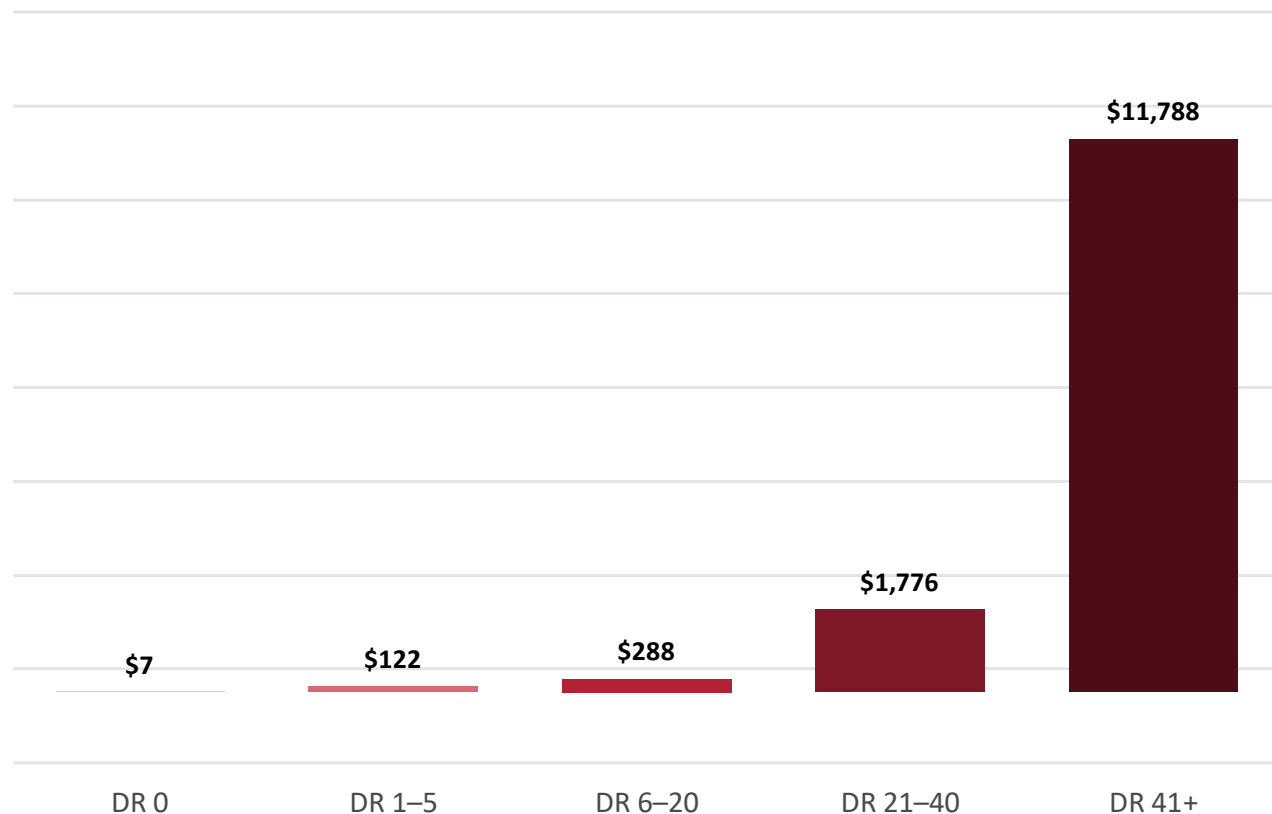
Two supporting tests

Channel. Web-billed firms (Stripe) run a \$30.78 median ARPU; mobile-billed firms (RevenueCat) \$5.00. App-store norms cap the ceiling at roughly a sixth.

Free tiers. Among B2C firms, a free tier coincides with a \$179 median against \$675 without — 3.8× lower. The same test in B2B shows no penalty at all (\$1,147 vs \$1,150).

Owned distribution beats rented audience

Median monthly revenue by domain authority band — the strongest single predictor in the file



Rank correlation with revenue

Domain rating $\rho = 0.52$

X followers $\rho = 0.17$

Search authority is three times the signal that social following is. Both are significant; only one is decisive.

The scale of the gap

- DR 41+ firms are 12% of the rated population and take 50% of all revenue.
- A DR 41+ firm's median month is 1,767× a DR 0 firm's.
- By contrast, 10k+ followers buys only a 14.5× median lift over zero followers.

THE MAIN STORY

Revenue is not luck. It is three levers, stacked.

Sell to businesses · price above \$50 per user · own a search-authority domain



65×

median revenue, three levers vs. none

71%

of three-lever firms clear \$10k/month

13.6%

of no-lever firms manage the same

Levers: audience = B2B · ARPU ≥ \$50 · domain rating ≥ 40. Tested on the 495 firms carrying all three fields.

Four moves, ranked by expected impact

Each tied to the insight that generated it and the evidence behind it

01

Reprice before you re-market

Move from a consumer price point to a business one. The median B2B user is worth \$49/month against \$9.34 in B2C, and ARPU rises from \$8 to \$89 as firms scale — price is the compounding half of growth.

Insight 4 • Highest impact

02

Build a search asset, not a following

Domain authority carries three times the rank correlation with revenue that follower count does (p 0.52 vs 0.17). Treat content and links as capital expenditure with a 12-month payback.

Insight 5 • High, slow-burning

03

Leave the crowd, or differentiate inside it

AI holds 27% of firms and 15% of revenue. If staying in AI, attach to a paying vertical — education and marketing both out-earn it 4–5× at the median.

Insight 3 • Medium, decisive

04

Kill the free tier in B2C — keep it in B2B

B2C firms with a free tier earn \$179 against \$675 without. The identical test in B2B shows no penalty. Segment the policy rather than copying it.

Insight 4 • Fast, low cost

The market is not short of builders. It is short of businesses.

What the data says

- A thousand firms produced \$15.6M in a month — and ten of them produced half of it.
- The cohort grew 29% against its own yearly average but only 3% against last quarter: the surge has cooled into a plateau.
- Crowding does not pay. The most populated category earns the least per firm.
- The gap between a \$400 month and a \$24,000 month is not effort or luck. It is who you sell to, what you charge, and whether you own your distribution.

Limitations worth stating

- Self-selected directory: firms opt in, so failures are under-represented and success is likely overstated.
- Single snapshot: trend is inferred from nested revenue windows, not observed month by month.
- Traffic missing for 82% of rows — no conversion or CAC analysis is possible.
- Association, not causation: no lever here is proven to cause revenue.

If you take one thing away: stop optimising the product and start optimising who it is sold to, what it costs, and how it is found.

Questions

Happy to go deeper on method, on any single figure, or on the rows I excluded and why.

1,000

firms analysed

\$15.6M

monthly revenue

$\rho = 0.52$

top predictor

65×

three-lever lift

Source: TrustMRR 1,000-row dataset, frozen 30 July 2026 · Analysis prepared by Aaryan